OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Shoalhaven Inclusion & Access Committee: 29-month action, blank cost line

Sent 12 October 2026 · To Shoalhaven City Council · Response requested by 2 November 2026

12 October 2026

To: Mr Andrew Constance, Chief Executive Officer, Shoalhaven City Council
council@shoalhaven.nsw.gov.au

Copy: The Mayor and Councillors, Shoalhaven City Council
Ms Katelin McInereny MP, Member for Kiama
Ms Liza Butler MP, Member for South Coast
Ms Fiona Phillips MP, Member for Gilmore

From: Stephen Prothero, Eye on Shoalhaven Council
Subject: Inclusion & Access Advisory Committee: is it the best use of time and money, and what can be done?

Dear Mr Constance and local Members,

I have read the agenda for the Inclusion & Access Advisory Committee meeting of 19 October 2026 (IA 18457) and the minutes of 30 March 2026. I am writing to ask whether the Committee, as it is run now and as it is proposed to be wound up, is the best use of staff time and public money, and what can be done to get better results for people with disability in the Shoalhaven.

What the papers show
1. One transport action took 29 months. On 20 May 2024 the Committee resolved (IA24.3) to ask staff to write to the local Members seeking funding for a peak body to coordinate data on accessible transport options and on the transport needs of people with disability. The 19 October agenda proposes closing the action, citing three Disability Inclusion Action Plan actions (2.6, 2.16 and 2.17) on paths, crossings and bus stops. The papers do not say whether the letters were sent or whether any reply was received.

1. **The process has been slow. The action log records a meeting without a quorum on 12 August 2024, repeated deferrals to the next meeting, and four reallocations of the action between officers in 2026.**
2. **Meeting time. The 30 March meeting ran 85 minutes with 19 people recorded. Most of it was presentations. It produced three housekeeping resolutions on the action table and one substantive resolution (accessible parking at the Services Australia building), all by consent.**
3. **Attendance. Apart from one observer, none of the external agency and service representatives on the membership list is recorded as present on 30 March,**

including Community Transport and Health.

4. Sequencing. Report IA26.6 says the Committee will need to be disestablished after the 19 October workshop, yet the reference group's governance, structure and operation are still to be developed from that workshop. The DIAP 2027-2030 is still a draft. A September 2025 note in the action log said the new DIAP would be effective from July 2026.
5. Cost. IA26.7 says there is no budget and so no financial implications. The Financial Implications section of IA26.6 is blank. On my own rough estimate, using stated assumptions (eight sessions, six staff, $100 an hour fully loaded, plus preparation and transition work), the staff time involved since May 2024 is about $54,000, within a range of $23,000 to $114,000. This is my estimate only; Council holds the actual figures. For comparison, a regional NSW council recently put the cost of an accessible bus stop upgrade at about $20,000 a stop, so the central estimate is roughly two to three stops.

The question

Is the Committee, in its present form and in its proposed transition, the best use of staff time and public money? I ask Council to answer that on the actual costs and outcomes, and I ask the local Members whether they can say what became of the 2024 funding request. I ask thos questions to goto all that are set out in the “TO” bar of this email.

What I ask

1. Were the IA24.3 letters to the local Members sent? Please provide copies and any replies.
2. What staff hours and cost has the Committee consumed from May 2024 to date, including the transition work?
3. Will the Committee be disestablished before the reference group and the DIAP 2027-2030 are in place? What is the timetable for each?
4. Will the workshop outputs be published, and will the wider community be able to comment on the reference group model before it is settled?
5. How many bus stops have been upgraded under Action 2.17, at what cost per stop, and has Council applied for State bus stop funding?
6. What is the cost and the backlog of the kerb ramp works that staff told the Committee were deferred for lack of funding?
7. Why is the Financial Implications section of IA26.6 blank?

What can be done

• Tie every Committee action to a deliverable, a named owner and a date, and close an action only when its original resolution is met or the Committee formally amends it.
• Keep the Committee in place until its replacement and the new DIAP are adopted, so there is no gap.
• Report staff hours and cost per Committee cycle to Council each year, so that "no budget" is not read as "no cost".

• Take agency updates in writing in the agenda pack, and move presentations to a pre-read so meeting time goes to questions and decisions.
• Make attendance and quorum more reliable with a year-ahead calendar, named alternates and remote attendance.
Here are my detailed observations

I would be grateful for a reply to these questions.

Yours sincerely,

Stephen Prothero
Independent community journalist | Publisher, Eye on Shoalhaven Council

M | E
Substack steveprothero.substack.com
Facebook group https://www.facebook.com/groups/2691340771067814
